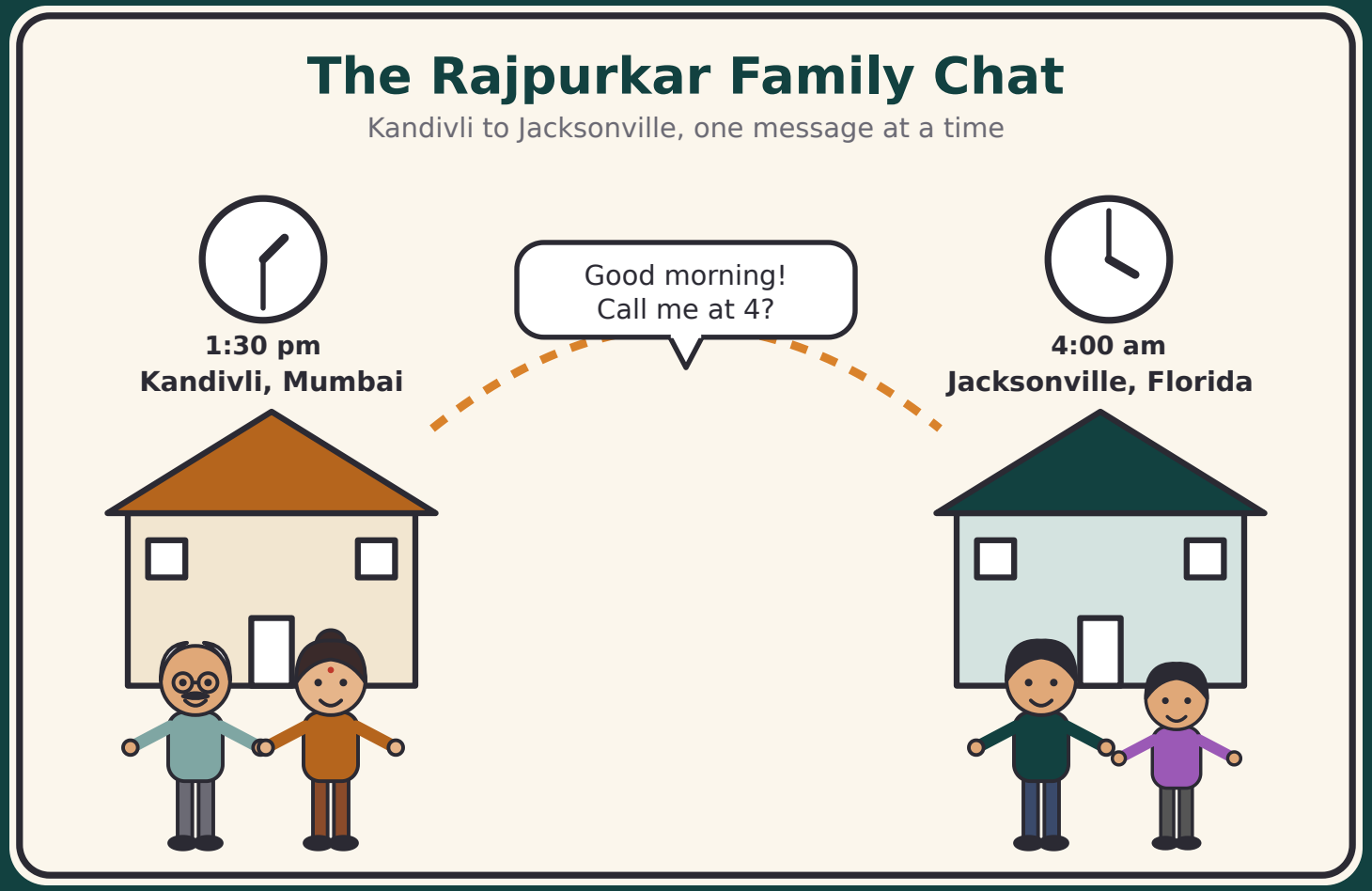
A DRAFT STORYBOOK · OCTOBER 2026

The Rajpurkar Family Chat

Kandivli ↔ Jacksonville, one message at a time

Sample of nine chapters · chronological · cartoons are original stylised sketches, not likenesses



CAST

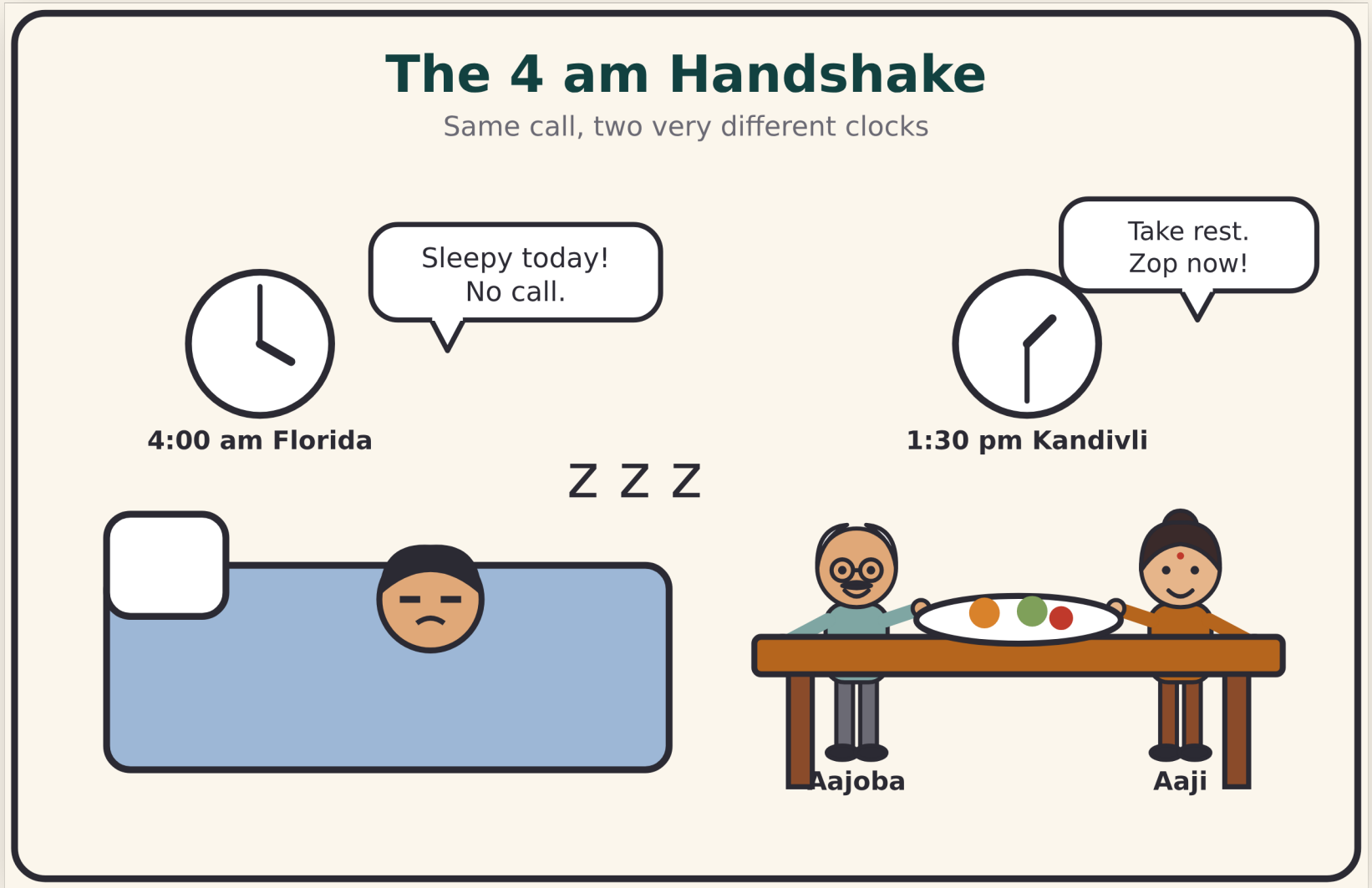
Meet the family

Aajoba	Kandivli, Mumbai. Careful reader of every photo and certificate. Signs off with "Take rest." Spots comets before anyone.
Aaji	Kandivli, Mumbai. Daily good-mornings, devotional forwards, food-as-love, and a pointing finger that means "look at this!"
Amit	Jacksonville, Florida. Runner, photographer, storyteller. Calls at 4 am his time, unless he is "sleepy today".
Prajakta	Jacksonville. Teacher-certification exams, birthdays, and the person who keeps the household moving.
Dhanesh	Amit's elder son: tabla, robotics, SAT, then off to university.
Yuvan	Amit's younger son: artist, pianist, telescope builder, and the family's future memoirist, according to Aajoba.

Two homes, 9½ hours apart. The chat is the bridge.

CHAPTER 1

The 4 am Handshake



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The 4 am Handshake

Every story needs a heartbeat, and this one has an alarm clock.

When it is 4 am in Jacksonville, it is half past one in the afternoon in Kandivli, which is exactly when Aajoba and Aaji have finished lunch and might, in theory, take a call. So Amit's alarm goes off in the dark, and he does the sensible thing: he checks his phone, then types one of two sentences.

Either: "*Tomorrow morning I will go running, then call you.*"

Or, far more often: "*Sleepy today.*"

Across the chat, about 127 of his messages sit between 3 and 5 am and say some version of the second one. Nobody is offended. Aajoba replies, "Take rest." Aaji, who is never short of an emoji, writes, "Zop now sleep," and adds a row of little sleeping faces.

On 18 February 2023 Amit spelt out the arithmetic for good: "*I will call you after your lunch, which will be my 4:30 am.*" It is the most romantic sentence in the whole archive, if you are a time-zone enthusiast.

The ritual survives into 2025 and 2026, only the app changes: the calls move to Arattai.

> **Sidebar: how to read the chat.** "Sleepy" = *no call today, but I was thinking of you.* A photo of a running log = *I did get up after all.*

CHAPTER 2

Two Comets Over Jacksonville



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Two Comets Over Jacksonville

January 2023, and the sky is putting on a show: comet C/2022 E3, known to its friends as ZTF.

Amit tracks it like a goalkeeper. On 11 January the links start. On 12 January: "*Cannot see with eyes... it's beside the moon.*" By 14 January he sends a walking photo with the caption **"two comets showing"**, one above the moon and one to its right, and it is Aajoba, from Mumbai, on a phone screen, who spots them. He is not done: on 18 January Amit introduces the family to Star Walk 2, an app that points at constellations. On the 19th he asks, "*Where is the moon? Can you spot?*" Aajoba, without hesitation: "*Down center.*"

A few days before, on 7 January, Amit had compared a SpaceX launch from 8 December with a rocket trail he had seen on the 16th, noting that Jacksonville is often close enough to see launches in daylight. Aajoba's verdict: **"Now we know the truth."**

This is the first of many sky chapters. There will be a solar eclipse, a lunar eclipse, a loaned telescope, Saturn's rings, and Titan. Always with a reply from Aajoba: "*Very clear pic.*"

CHAPTER 3

The Dropped Call



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The Dropped Call

14–18 February 2023. The grandparents are on a tour of Gujarat: a museum and palace where no photos are allowed, the Sayaji Garden toy train, the Amul dairy at Anand ("food at the Amul food court was excellent"), and the Krishna temple at Dakor.

The finale is a classic. On 18 February, Amit rings while the two of them are rushing to catch the return train.

"*No connection.*"

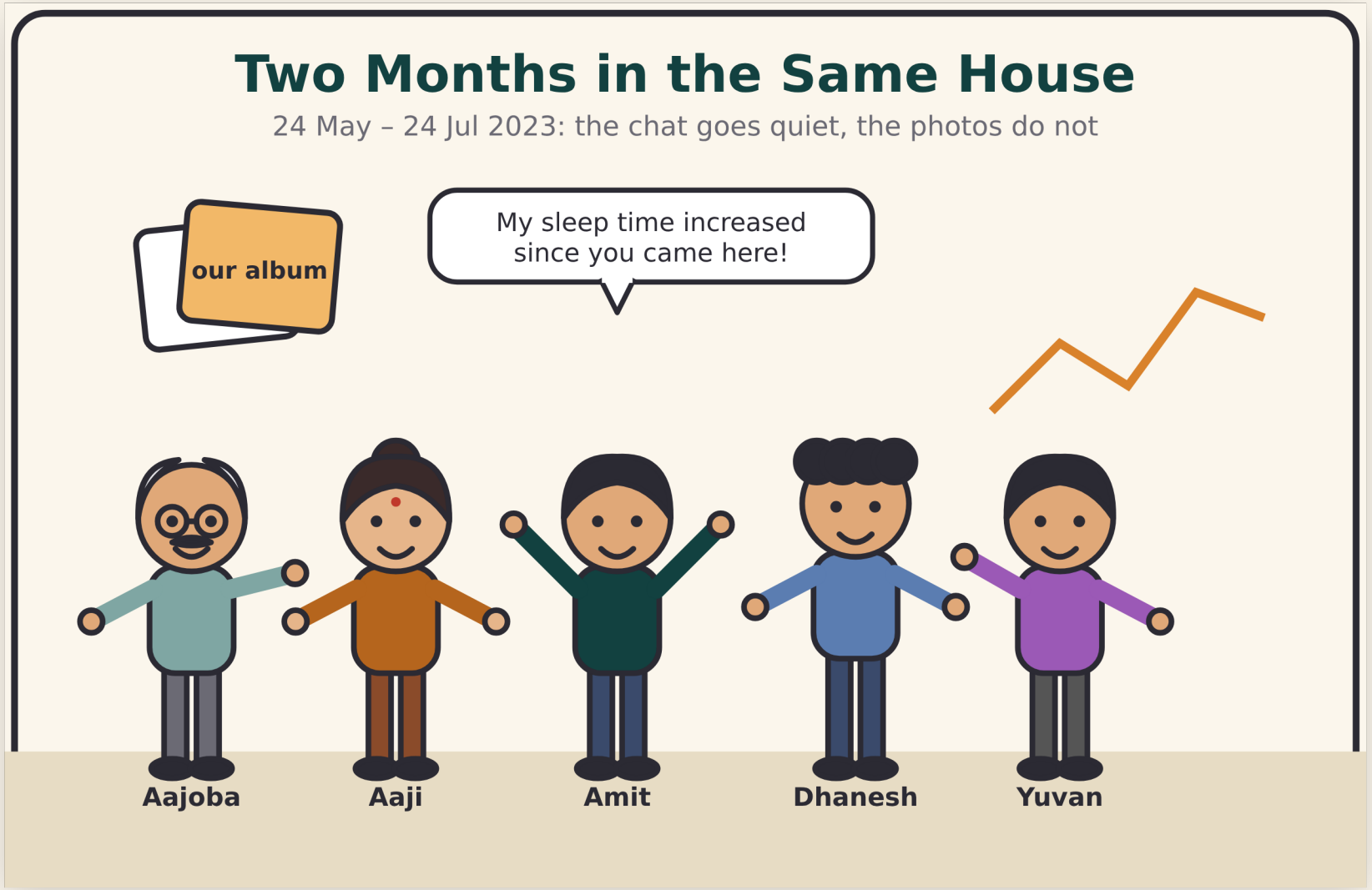
"*But you have internet.*"

"*See, we talked.*"

That last line, apparently, counts. Aajoba reports, with the satisfaction of a man who has caught his train and kept his dignity: **"Just now reached home safely."**

Amit responds the next day with two Google Photos albums: "*and your trip.*" The family has a way of turning any journey, even a blurry one, into an album.

Two Months in the Same House



CHAPTER 4

Two Months in the Same House

On 24 May 2023, Aajoba and Aaji flew in through Dubai and landed in Jacksonville ("Sitting at the meet-and-greet area near baggage claim"). For two months the chat, ironically, goes almost silent: you do not text people who are in the next room.

But the photos keep coming. Amit pushes batches of 30 to 100 pictures into the group so the grandparents will have their own copies, and re-shares one Google Photos album, "*our album*", four times, the last time on departure day.

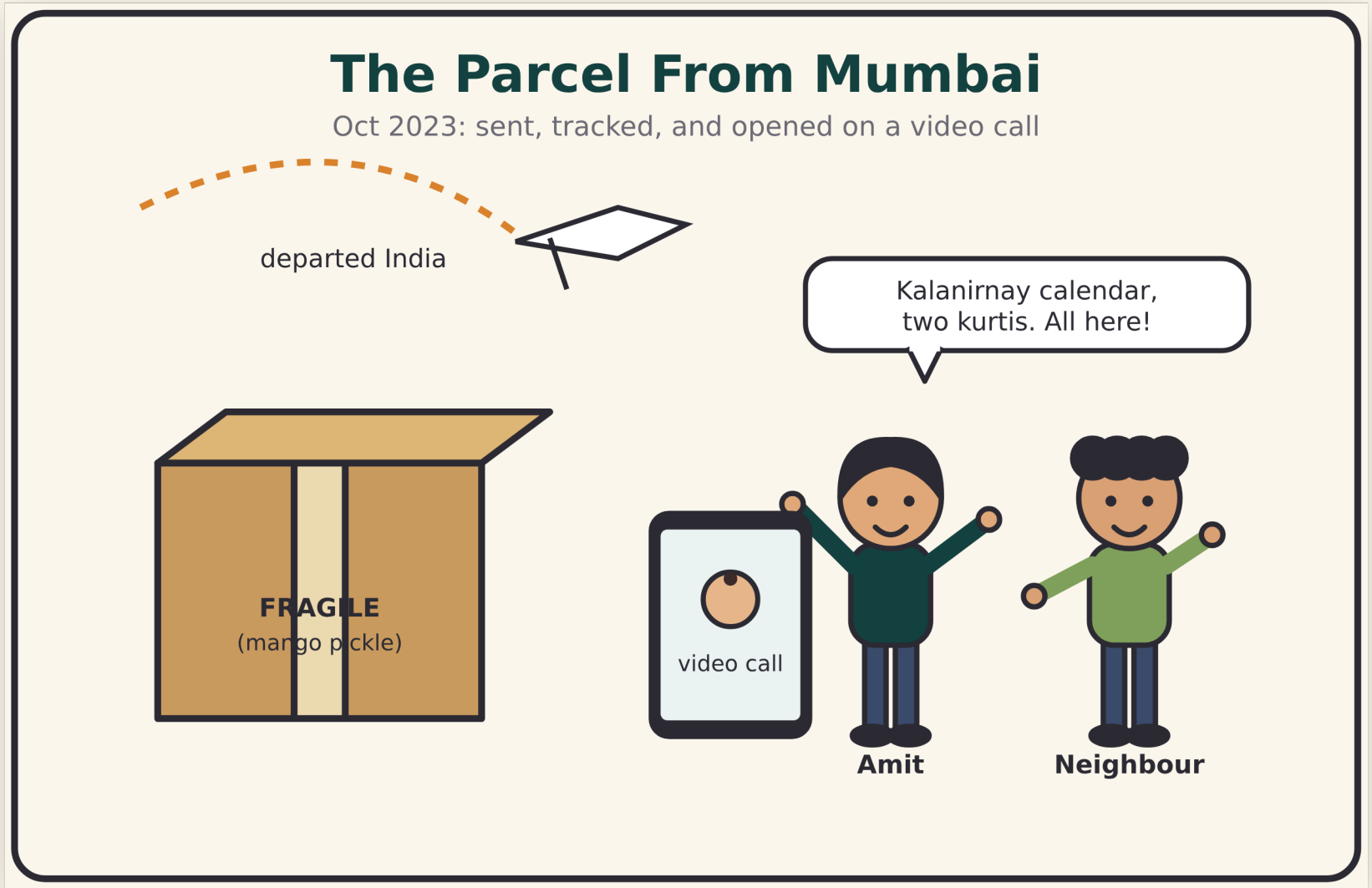
Small moments make the cut. On **19 June** a chart appears with the caption "*My sleep times increased since you came here*": Amit's first graph in the archive, and a rare piece of data-driven gratitude. On **22 June** a running video arrives titled "Motivation for Pappaji," with the question: "*So when should we see Pappaji running like this?*" Aajoba's answer is a row of cross faces and a shiver.

There are also Lego City, Little Talbot Island, an Arlington Lions Club park, and a "first song" on the piano for Ms Barbara, Yuvan's teacher.

On **24 July** the visit ends in the same way it began, with a phone. Amit tracks the flight to Dubai and then Mumbai, and Aajoba reports, "*On our way to Kandivli.*" Back in Florida, Amit writes the line that sums up the summer: Prajakta drove home, he was on calls, Dhanesh had a class from the car, "*We ate the pulav; jeera rice is still there.*"

CHAPTER 5

The Parcel From Mumbai



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The Parcel From Mumbai

17 October 2023. "*Parcel sent today.*"

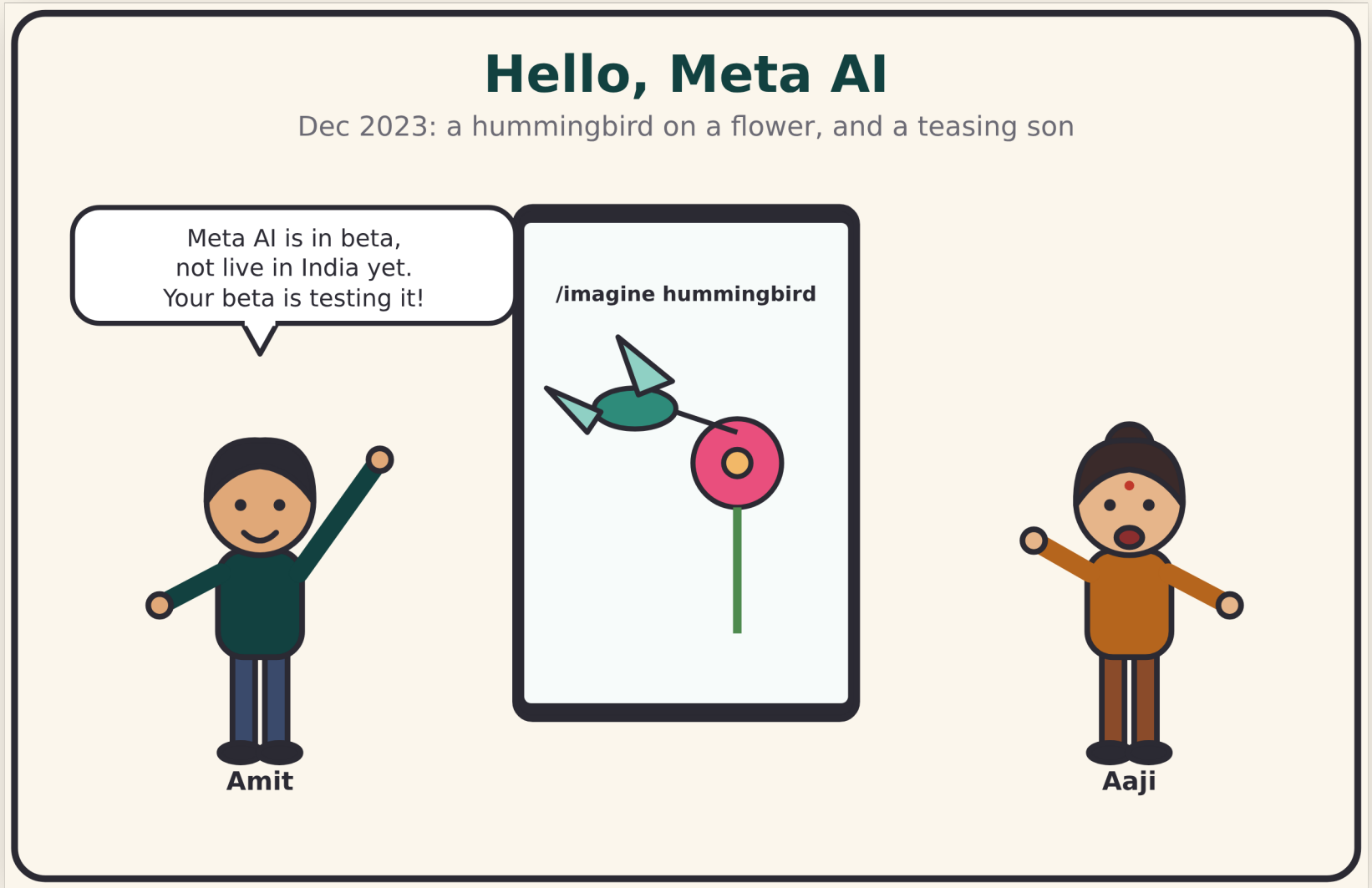
For the next ten days the family follows a cardboard box across the world. On 20 October a tracker screenshot reads, "*So far it's saying departed India.*" On 27 October it arrives, and Amit and a neighbour open it live on a video call, so Aaji in Mumbai can watch her own gifts being unwrapped half a world away. Inside, a Marathi *kalanirnay* calendar and two kurtis for Prajakta, which arrive on 7 November.

Earlier that month Amit's second phone, the "305" number, goes missing for a day ("*my 305 phone has gone missing*"), turns up in his bag, and quietly confirms what this chapter is about: the family's real address is the group chat.

It is also the season of drawing. Amit takes up oil pastels on 7 October ("still rough"), and Aaji, on the 10th, blesses it: "*Develop this valuable art, it will give you full happiness.*"

CHAPTER 6

Hello, Meta AI



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11 December 2023. Amit types a strange command into the family chat: **"@Meta AI /imagine hummingbird on a flower."** He explains that the feature is in beta and not yet live in India, but reachable through Facebook Messenger. Then he teases his mother: "*Your beta is trying to test it.*" (In Hindi, *beta* means "son", so the joke was a pun on "beta version".)

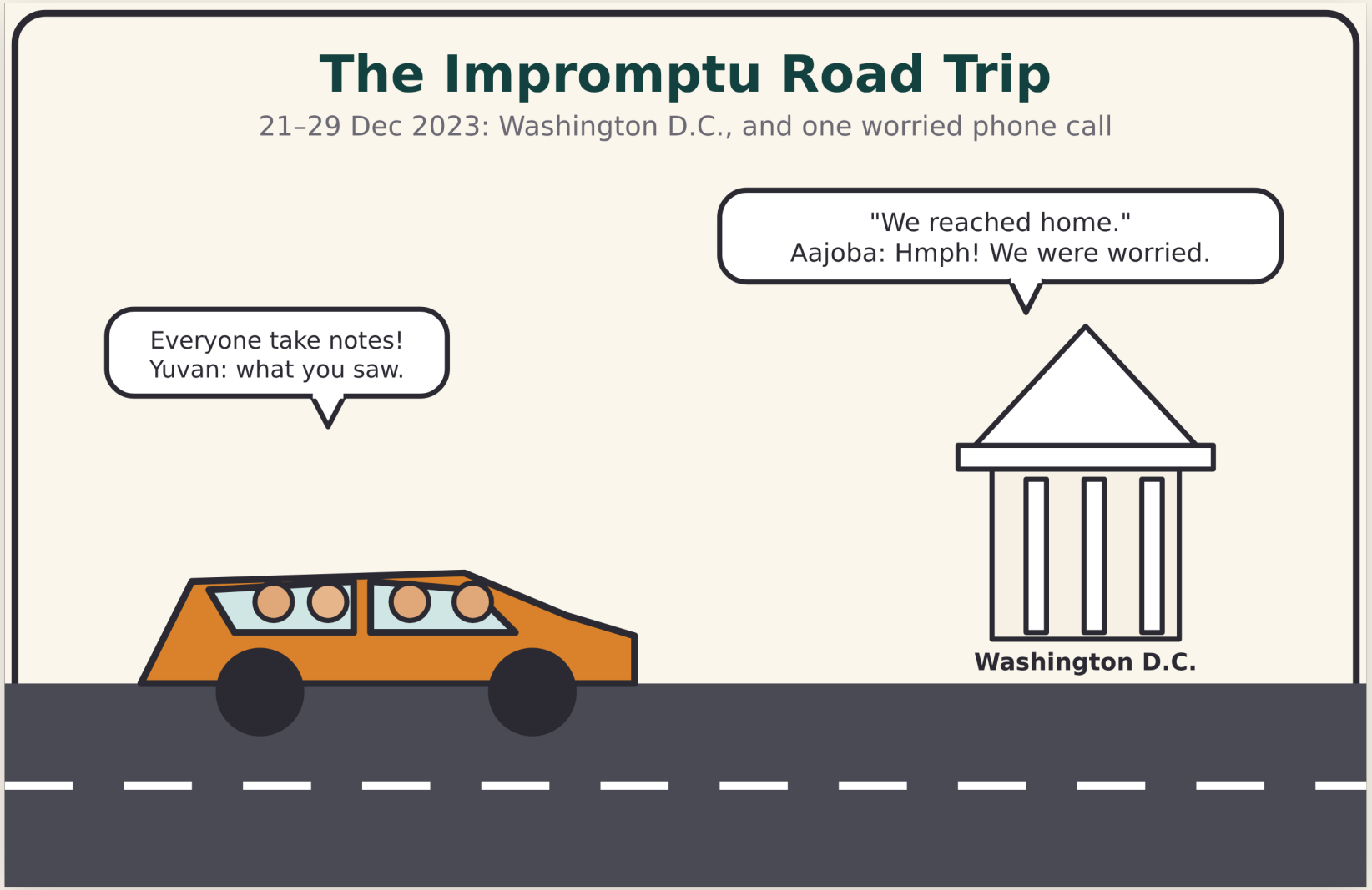
Three days later, Meta's privacy notice lands in the group chat, the family's first brush with the terms of service. His second prompt, for an Indian family meeting grandparents in Konkan, does not work ("*need to get my prompt better*"). The hummingbird at dusk does.

By 31 December the experiments are family fun: pictures marked "*created by AI!!*", including Yuvan beside a lion. ("*Now who is the lion with our Yuvan? Kandolicha Sinha??*")

It is the start of a long thread. Three years later, in September 2026, Aaji herself writes an aarti and sets it to music with AI.

CHAPTER 7

The Impromptu Road Trip



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The Impromptu Road Trip

21 December 2023. "*We are doing an impromptu trip… road trip to Washington D.C. tomorrow morning.*"

The photographs come in waves on 22, 23 and 24 December, with an album on the 24th. Aajoba is amazed. "*My God, so many photos,*" he writes on Christmas Day, and then gives the boys homework: **"Ask Yuvan to write about this trip: what he saw, what he liked, what he understood. Let him take notes so that he would remember things in order."**

On the 28th: "*It appears kids have seen lots of things.*"

And then the drive home. For many hours there is silence, which in a family with two grandparents in Mumbai is a dangerous thing. At 11:45 am on the 29th, Amit writes: "*Hi. We reached home.*"

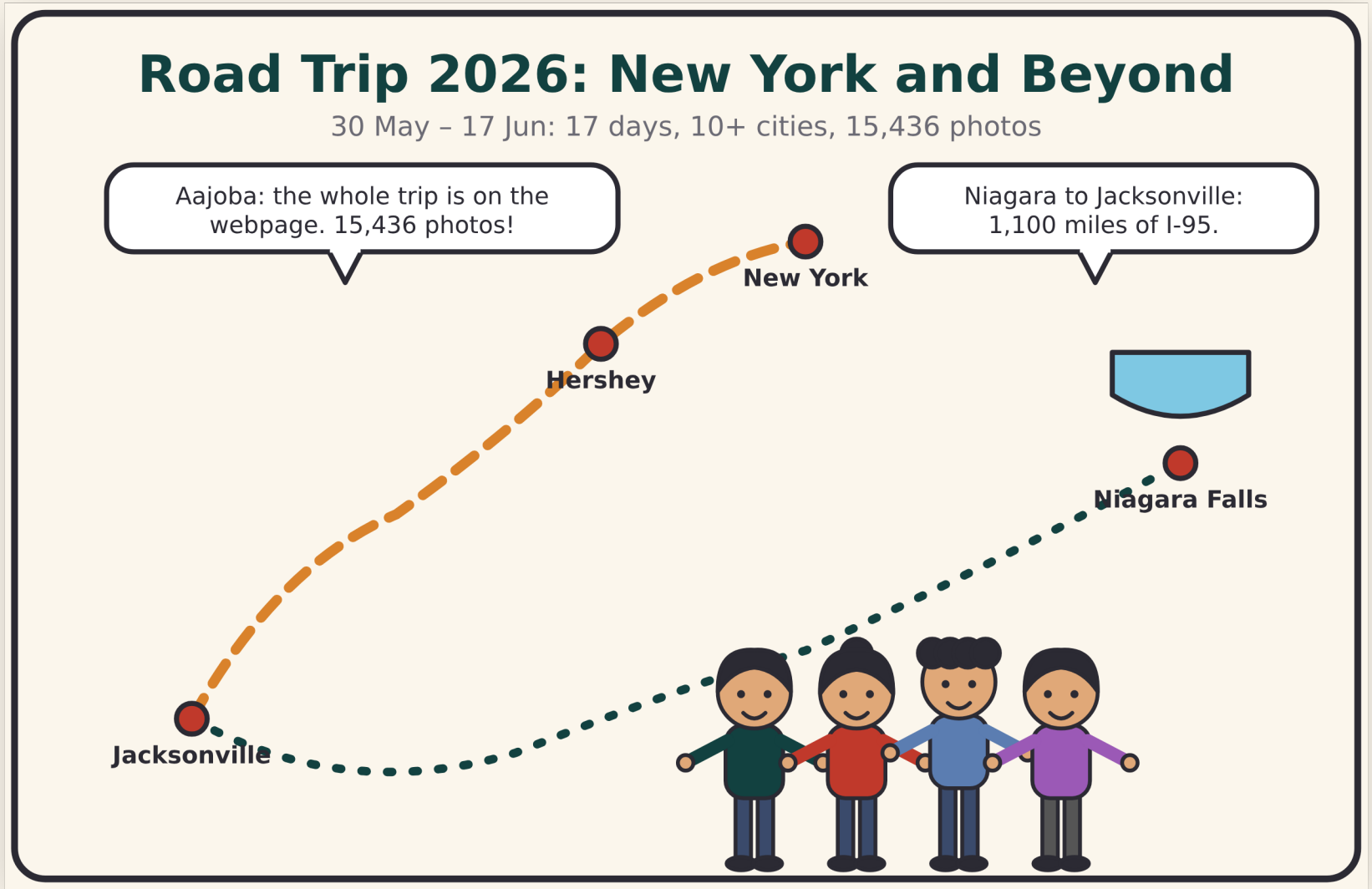
Aajoba's reply is a row of angry faces. Amit's answer is honest and gentle: "*I know you both got worried; but I just got tired and exhausted.*"

A week later, on 1 January 2024, Amit sends a trip summary. Aajoba responds with a wish, and a warning: "*When will these boys write their memoir?*"

> **Note for the real book.** This chapter is, in a way, where this book begins. Aajoba was already wondering about a memoir in January 2024.

CHAPTER 8

Road Trip 2026: New York and Beyond



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Road Trip 2026: New York and Beyond

Seventeen days. The Rajpurkar family flew from Orlando to Newark, on a morning when Amit wrote, simply, "*Taking off from home in the morning,*" and then worked their way through more than ten cities: New York (including a photo of a Bank of India branch), Saratoga Springs, an automobile museum, Niagara Falls, Hershey, Raleigh, and an overnight stop in Savannah.

The last day, 17 June, was a single drive: "*Niagara to Jacksonville is 1,100 miles,*" Amit explained, and Aajoba, doing the maths from Mumbai, noted it was roughly twenty hours of I-95.

The family turned their trip into a webpage, *Road Trip 2026: New York & Beyond: A Family Travel Log*, with **15,436 photographs**. It arrived in the chat on 24 June. On 27 June Aajoba replied that everything was there.

It is, among other things, the best proof of Aajoba's old rule from 2023: *take notes, so that you remember things in order.*

CHAPTER 9

The Last Message (So Far)



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The Last Message (So Far)

The archive ends on 5 October 2026, at 9:58 pm, in the middle of a sentence.

The last days of the record are gentle ones. On 1 October, the first of the month, Amit runs: "*Got a very good pace.*" On 3 October he walks in the American Heart Association walk and posts 21 photos; Aajoba: "*Good crowd. It appears many other groups also joined this walk.*" A sitar-based aarti from the Saras Baug Ganpati temple in Pune arrives from Aaji: "*How melodious.*"

A new sender appears, apparently Yuvan from his own number: "*There was 0.1 inches of rain yesterday. As it was a drizzle.*" Two days later he asks his grandparents for ten minutes to fill in a form for the NOAA Ocean Guardian Youth Ambassador Program. Aaji, at 10:01 pm: "*Ok dear, I will see.*"

And then, at 9:58 pm on the 5th, Aaji sends a line in Marathi (roughly: "*This had made me crazy; I'd gone totally crazy for this…*"). The file ends there. We do not know what it was about.

Which is, perhaps, the point of a family chat: it never really ends. It just stops for the night, until somebody says "*Good morning.*"

NEXT

What happens next

This sample shows one possible shape for the book. To grow it into a full draft we could:

1. Add the other quarters (2024 to 2026) as further chapters; the storyline already has them.
2. Add themed interludes: *The boys, milestone by milestone*; *Grandparents on the road*; *Looking up*; *Festivals in two countries*; *Amit's running story*.
3. Replace the cartoons with an illustrator's version; art briefs can be written for each chapter.
4. Ask the family to correct names and details, and to supply the stories the chat only hints at.

Open questions for the family

- Is the +1 (904) number in October 2026 Yuvan's own phone?
- What were the 2023 visa papers and Prajakta's April 2023 tickets for?
- Where did Amit travel on 16–24 July 2025?
- Which chapter should be written out in full first?

Draft v0.1 · cartoons are original stylised sketches; text is condensed from `rjp_fmly_archive_storyline.md`.